

CHAPTER NINE

The McLean, Va. Years

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After returning from home leave we had to go through the usual trauma of getting lodging. We had sold our house in Fairfax, Virginia before we left for Rio de Janeiro so we had to find something else to buy, preferably in McLean, Va. which was closer to work, the Agency headquarters being located in Langley. We took temporary lodging at the Park Arlington Apartments and eventually found a satisfactory house at 1250 Kensington Rd. in McLean, just off the Dolley Madison Parkway and about a ten minute drive to work for me. We bought an old Dodge Polara to have some transportation until we decided what other car, if any, that we might need.

Shortly after buying the house on Kensington Rd. we contracted to have the basement finished so that we would have some extra room for a family room, extra bath and some storage. The cost of this was \$2438.00 according to a cancelled check which I still have in my possession.

After reporting finally for work, I was assigned to be the Chief of what was known as the Collection Group in the Soviet Bloc Division of the Deputy Director for Plans (also known at that time as the Clandestine Services). This was a Supergrade position although at the time I was only a GS-15, which I had received as a result of my reorganization work of SR Division prior to my Rio assignment. The Collection Group was one of the components that I created back in 1964. The Group consisted of four branches employing approximately 50 people ranging in grade from GS-5/7 secretaries to a substantial number of GS-12's, 13's and about 8 GS-14's as branch or deputy branch chiefs. The group was experiencing very low morale. It had been without a group chief for five months (awaiting my return) since the previous chief had had a heart attack and it was being run rather loosely by the penultimate chief, who had become the Chief of Operations of the Division and who was a difficult if not semi-psychotic individual.

My first responsibility was to instill in the group a sense of cohesiveness and regain some degree of esprit de corps which had been missing for a considerable period of time. This was not an easy task. By their very nature intelligence officers are quite a different breed and it took a great deal of tact, persuasiveness and diplomacy to get the group on a productive keel again. The branches were quite diverse in their responsibilities, one was responsible for operational activity inside the Soviet Union (including running our Moscow Station) while the others were devoted to operations against the Soviets outside the confines of the Soviet Union proper, such as Scientific and Technical delegations visiting the Western world, military representations abroad, and Soviet maritime personnel (ranging from military (naval) to whaling in the South Atlantic.

I found myself basically in conflict with several of the people in the front office who had adopted an almost paranoid defensive position with respect to the opposition service with which we had to contend, i.e. the Soviet KGB. I felt that they were so immersed in ongoing operational problems that they could not or would not recognize the changes that were occurring in international politics and how these changes were and might be affecting our operational posture. These fundamental differences in points of view eventually led to my leaving the Division for a position on the Personnel Management Staff in the summer of 1968.

I spent many hours in liaison and negotiation with individuals from other directorates of CIA as well as other government agencies, particularly NSA, the Department of State and the Defense Department. The extent of interest and involvement in approvals required for operational activity is not comprehended by those on the outside and particularly by the press which relishes the idea of out of control sinister activities about which nobody else knows anything. For example, I spent a considerable amount of time dealing with officials at NSA (the National Security Agency) for support in certain sensitive activities where my group needed the information that only NSA could supply, e.g. up to date information on the movement of a Soviet vessel in which we had an operational interest.

My first assignment in the Church after our return from Rio was as a teacher of the Family Relations class in Sunday School. This didn't last too long, however, since I was soon called to be the High Priest Group Leader of the McLean Ward over about 45-50 High Priests which included some pretty high-powered individuals such as James Fletcher, head of NASA, Frank Kimball, VP and General Counsel of the Marriot Corporation, Ted Bell, Secretary of what later became known as the Dept. of Education (to which he was appointed later in the first Reagan administration, and Thomas S. Kimball, Exec. Vice-President of the National Wildlife Association. In January 1968 Marion was called to be the Relief Society President, a position she had served in before in other wards.

The year 1968 was one of turmoil in the United States, both because of the Vietnam War and also because of racial issues. Martin Luther King, the leader of the drive for equality for the black people, was killed in Memphis and this incident set off a wave of rioting throughout the United States. In Washington, D.C. there were blocks of stores burned indiscriminately. We watched it on television but never did go down to see the areas destroyed. What was ironical about it was that the black people were burning and destroying buildings and houses that belonged to other black people. It was totally insane. Also this year, Robert F. Kennedy, the brother of John Kennedy, the president who had

been assassinated, was himself killed while on a campaign tour in Los Angeles. Lyndon Johnson, deeply morose about his failure in the Vietnam fiasco, chose not to run for re-election and the election that year was won by Richard M. Nixon, the vice-president under Dwight D. Eisenhower.

Ron received his mission call after he turned nineteen and upon finishing the quarter at the university. He was called to Sao Paulo, Brazil mission. Marion went out to Utah to help him get ready for his mission and go to the temple with him for his endowments. Howard S. McDonald, who had been president at B.Y.U. when we were married was now the President of the Salt Lake temple, so Marion had an opportunity to see and talk a lot with him. Marion stayed in Utah while Ron was in the mission home in Salt Lake. I was really sorry that I couldn't have spent some of this time with him but my work was so demanding at that time that I couldn't get away. Ron didn't have to spend much time in language training since he already had had a good exposure to the Portuguese language while living in Brazil and continuing its study at B.Y.U. He left for his mission in early June. Since the missionaries had a stop over in New York City, the family drove up there to see him off. What a sight to see all those young men in dark suits and white shirts loaded down with cameras and attache cases.

On the way home we had quite an adventure. It was dark and raining and in spite of thinking we had the proper instructions, we made a wrong turn off the freeway and found ourselves in the parking lot of Shea stadium, the home of the New York Mets baseball team. To top things off our generator started giving us problems and we had to pull off the freeway to get it serviced, which fortunately required only that the belt be tightened.